finish the harvest." At Paulette's frown, she added, "But when I finish, I would like to draw a still life, one that is different from any of the others I've done."

Rose smiled as her mind jumped back to those first days in Combleux. Rose had been cleaning the dishes after dinner in the kitchen and Virginie had come alongside her. "I have something I'd like to show you," she'd said, clutching a leather-bound book against her chest. "Leave the dishes for me to finish later."

Rose had dried her hands and followed Virginie to the two chairs near the window. The cost of electricity had gone up so much that the lights were never turned on in the main house and reserved only for the *chai*. The autumn days were shortening. Virginie lit two candles and placed a book on the table.

"This book belonged to my father," Virginie said softly. "He was a shopkeeper, but his passion was painting. In his free time, he studied the old Masters." She handed the book to Rose. "You might enjoy looking through it, as the book has all the old Masters who were Papa's favorite painters. Keep it for as long as you're here. Maybe it will inspire you."

"Thank you, this is so kind of you to share," Rose said, wanting to ask if Virginie's father had also been a painter, but upon opening the book, she was drawn into a riveting image that took her breath away. A wooden table set against a gray wall, a green velvet cloth covering all but the edges of the table. On the cloth, objects were arranged: opened oysters glistening on a silver platter, walnuts with fine lines like an old woman's face, cracked hazelnut shells with edges sharp as a knife, a half-peeled lemon's stippled rind curled like a cat tail on another silver platter, a clock, a gold key attached to a sky blue velvet ribbon, an engraved silver dish with a stem, and shimmering glass goblets half filled with wine. Rose inched closer, hardly believing what she saw.

Inside the goblets, floating in the wine and at the upper rim of the glass, were windows. She squinted, sure that inside the windows another reflection floated—was it the painter? Her gaze shifted to the lemon's golden light reflected like beams of the sun on the silver platter. It was all light and reflection, gorgeous soft and hard light that seemed to reach back to eternity, doubling and tripling on itself in the images on that table and in the room—the room that wasn't in the painting and yet present, as if the